

Tianhua Zou

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Renmin University of China

RESEARCH INTERESTS

My research centers on sustainable development, at the intersection of development in less-developed regions and among disadvantaged populations, and of environmental policy and the energy transition. I approach these questions with high-quality microdata from large-scale household surveys and RCTs, frontier causal inference powered by machine learning and LLMs, and AI for economics, as an active user and advocate of AI agents in research.

EDUCATION

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| • Renmin University of China
<i>Ph.D. candidate in Applied Econ.</i> | 2024.9-2027.6 (expected)
Beijing, China |
| • Stanford University
<i>Visiting Student Researcher</i> | 2025.9-2026.8 (expected)
CA, USA |
| • Renmin University of China
<i>M.S. in Applied Econ.</i> | 2022.9 - 2024.6
Beijing, China |
| • University of International Business and Economics
<i>B.S. in Finance</i> | 2018.9 - 2022.6
Beijing, China |

PUBLICATIONS

- [1] Lunyu Xie, Tianhua Zou, Joshua Linn, Haosheng Yan* (2024), **Can Building Subway Systems Improve Air Quality? New Evidence from Multiple Cities and Machine Learning**, *Environmental and Resource Economics*, 87(4), 1009–1044. (2024 Outstanding Publication in ERE)

WORKING PAPERS

- Cooling Inequality on a Hotter Planet, with [Lunyu Xie](#) and Guilan Li
- How Local Discretion Shapes the Effects of a Central Mandate: Evidence from China's Clean Heating Policy, with [Lunyu Xie](#) and [Yuheng Zhao](#)

WORK IN PROGRESS

- A Second Pair of Hands: Intergenerational Co-parenting and the Effects of Parental Training on Early Childhood Development in Rural China, with [Scott Rozelle](#) and [Lei Wang](#)
- Housing Structure, Network Externalities, and Optimal Subsidy Dynamics, with [Mengjia Hu](#), [Joshua Linn](#), and [Lunyu Xie](#)
- Information Provision and Electric-Vehicle Adoption: A Randomized Field Experiment

EXPERIENCE

I am actively involved in the following labs:

- Sustainable Development and Poverty Alleviation Lab, School of Applied Economics, Renmin University of China (with Prof. [Lunyu Xie](#))
- Lead the China Residential Energy Consumption Survey (**CRECS**)
- **Rural Education Action Program (REAP)**, Stanford Center on China's Economy and Institutions (SCCEI), Stanford University (with Prof. [Scott Rozelle](#))
- **Economics for Sustainability and Energy Transition (eSET)**, Doerr School of Sustainability, Stanford University (with Prof. [Shanjun Li](#))

SELECTED AWARDS

- National scholarship for Postgraduates, Outstanding Graduates of Beijing

SELECTED CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- 2025 Chinese Economists Society (CES) China Annual Conference, July 2025, Guangzhou.
- 9th Annual Workshop of the Sustainable Energy Transitions Initiative, June 2024, Online.
- 10th Xiangzhang Annual Conference, April 2024, Nanjing.
- 3rd National Development Youth Forum (NSD, Peking University), April 2021, Beijing.